with Vijayakanth's DMDK being denied a promised Rajya Sabha seat. The pique hasn't eased: the party is holding back from finalising a pact with the AIADMK.

Neither OPS nor Dhinakaran can boast of being able to command the entire anti-DMK space, but their relevance is clear. The ex-CM still carries influence in southern districts like Theni and parts of Madurai, Dhinakaran, too, retains pockets of support across the south. During the 2024 election, which the AIADMK had fought without the BJP, both OPS and Dhinakaran had undermined its prospects in several southern constituencies. Adding to the intrigue, speculation is that the BJP's **K. Annamalai** is quietly encouraging the duo, seeing them as a way to weaken EPS.

Takeaways

- **Dhinakaran exits AIADMK alliance, OPS out too, DMDK in doubt**
- **Sengottaiyan says AIADMK must recall Sasikala, OPS et al**
- **Veterans unhappy at EPS's self-image as the undisputed inheritor of Jayalalithaa's legacy**

Inside the AIADMK, the churn is just as sharp, with veterans bristling at EPS's monopoly. On September 8, one of them, the 77-year-old K.A. Sengottaiyan, found himself stripped of all party posts. Why? A day earlier, he had demanded that all expelled and sidelined leaders—like OPS and **V.K. Sasikala**—be brought back into the party fold within 10 days.

A BIT ERODED?

Sengottaiyan is no minor figure. A former minister and nine-time MLA, he has been a loyalist since the MGR period and holds sway in the AIADMK's western strongholds, especially Erode and the Kongu belt. On cue, mass resignations from the cadre streamed into local party offices. By not even opening talks with Sengottaiyan, EPS clearly wants to show dissent will not be tolerated, even from veterans, and is willing to risk alienating swathes of the grassroots for that objective.

Not everyone is convinced of the strategic wisdom of such a stance internally, though it's getting voiced outside. OPS, for one, repeats his call for unity. "Only if everyone comes together can we win and rule again... We face multiple trials because forces within the AIADMK are divided," he says. Sasikala, too, backs Sengottaiyan, terming his unity call "the voice of the people of Tamil Nadu".

As a commentator put it, "EPS believes he's as charismatic as MGR or Jayalalithaa. But the fact is, he hasn't been able to deliver a single victory for his party."

Meanwhile, all roads seem to lead to Amit Shah, who recently had separate closed-door meetings with Sengottaiyan and EPS. BJP state chief Nainar Nagendran calls the rift an "internal matter", but admits defeating the DMK requires a united front. Presently, things are racing in precisely the opposite direction. ■

▶ RAJASTHAN

CONVERTING FAITH TO A POINT OF LAW

The state's anti-conversion bill surpasses all others in the stringency of its provisions

By **Rohit Parihar**

IF HISTORY WERE TO PROCEED BACKWARDS, a lot of powerful Rajput ruling dynasties from Rajasthan's past would face the mortification of being dragged in front of modern courts. Interfaith weddings were the currency of their power. But today, state by state, India seems to be converting to a different article of faith. And Rajasthan has not only become the latest to pass an anti-conversion bill, it has surpassed all others in the stringency of its provisions.

The Rajasthan Prohibition of Unlawful Religious Conversion Bill, 2025, marks the state's third legislative venture of its ilk, its 2005 and 2008 editions having failed to get

SAFFRON VETO Hindu groups protest forced conversion in Dausa, Jul. 6



ANI